

(7) Seventh-Day Adventist (Sda)

BRIEF INTRODUCTION

The Seventh-Day (in short SDA) Adventist Church considered mostly a Protestant denomination (though some Christians consider it to be a cult) with approximately 18 million members worldwide out of approximately 2 billion (2014 estimates) Christians. This movement grew out of the prophetic Millerite movement in the United States during the middle part of the 19th century and was formally established in 1863 under the guidance of prophetess Ellen G. White.

The Seventh-day Adventist Church traces its roots to Baptist preacher William Miller (1782–1849), who predicted the Second Coming of Jesus would occur sometime between 1843 and March 1844. After his predictions failed, William Miller faded into obscurity and so did most of his followers (known as Millerites). But a small group of followers under the guidance of young prophetess Ellen G. White (1827-1915), over the next 15 years, through biblical study and conferences shed new light on the second coming (Jesus had indeed come again, but not to Earth. Jesus had actually returned to the "Most Holy Place" of the heavenly sanctuary.) and series of Biblical truths forgotten since the early days of Christianity.

The movement was named Seventh-day Adventist at a meeting by the delegates on October 1, 1860. In May 21, 1863, through a meeting of delegates from all parts of America it constituted itself as a denomination and became an official organization. Ellen White, James White and Joseph Bates are the prominent founding figures of the Church.

The name Seventh-day Adventist is based on the Church's distinctive characteristics of observance of the Sabbath on Saturday, the seventh day of the week and an expectation of Christ's imminent second coming (advent) on this earth.

The movement grew in north America and in later part of nineteenth century through missionary work it spread to the rest of the world. The movement is governed by a General Conference, headquartered in Silver Spring, Maryland, USA, with smaller regions administered by 13 divisions, 122 union conferences, and 600 local conferences. Today the worldwide members include about 2 million in north America, 5.3 million in central and south America, 7 million in Africa, 3.5 million in Asia (2014 estimates).

The Seventh-day Adventist Church, as a of Protestant denomination share many basic beliefs of most Protestant denominations but differ in some with some of their unique beliefs.

In our following discussion we will focus only on unique aspects of The Seventh-day Adventist Church and where there are differences with other Protestant denominations. So it is important to read upon 'Branches of Christianity' and 'Protestantism' in our website before proceeding any further.

SOURCES OF RELIGIOUS/SACRED INFORMATION

The Seventh-day Adventist Church considers the holy Bible as the primary source of religious/sacred information.

The Church also considers the written works by Ellen White as authoritative. According to the 18th of the 28 Fundamental Beliefs, "Her writings speak with prophetic authority and provide comfort, guidance, instruction, and correction to the church."

KEY FEATURES OF BELIEF

(Only the unique features of The Seventh-day Adventist are discussed in this section)

There is currently '28 Fundamental Beliefs' laid out by the Seventh-day Adventist Church of which most are similar to most mainstream Protestant denominations. The most distinguishing beliefs of Seventh-day Adventists are their belief on the observance of the Sabbath day and its observance on Saturday (the seventh day); the doctrine of the heavenly sanctuary and investigative judgment; the status of Ellen G. White and her writings; their doctrine of the second coming and millennium and various dietary observances rooted in Jewish law.

STATUS OF ELLEN G. WHITE AND HER WRITINGS

The Seventh-day Adventists accept Ellen G. White (one of the founders) as a prophetess. And also considers her writings (based on revelations and prophetic visions) as authoritative and secondary source of religious information along with Bible (the primary source). The mainstream Christians for obvious reasons consider her to be a false prophet and her writings to be forgery.

CHRIST'S HEAVENLY SANCTUARY AND INVESTIGATIVE JUDGMENT

The Seventh-day Adventists believe that the heavenly sanctuary has two areas; the Holy Place and the Most Holy Place. Christ on his ascension from earth to heaven went into the Holy Place. And after 2300 years (in 1844) he went into the Most Holy Place to cleanse it before his second coming to earth. And from that moment on he began 'investigative (pre-advent) judgment'.

The investigate judgment identifies who is worthy of salvation in God's everlasting kingdom. Through this process Jesus identifies who among the dead are asleep in Christ and are worthy of resurrection; and also who among the living abiding in Christ, and are ready for translation into God's everlasting kingdom.

THE CHURCH

The Seventh-day Adventist Church is a centralized Church and its polity includes elements of representative, hierarchical and Presbyterian polity. Church authority is derived from the membership of local churches. Executive responsibility is given to representative bodies and officers to govern the Church. Four levels of Church organization (local Church, local conference, union conference, and general conference) lead from the individual believer to the worldwide Church organization. The 'General Conference' is the highest earthly authority for the Church. The local church has three-level hierarchical structure of ministers, elders, and deacons. The Church structure usually is modern and simple and devoid of statues and images.

THE CLERGY

The Seventh-day Adventist Church clergy usually consists of ministers (pastors), elders and deacons. Adventists do not believe in clerical celibacy. Currently the Church does not ordain women ministers. The Church also does not ordain homosexuals in ministry.

THE SACRAMENTS (OR ORDINANCES)

The Seventh-day Adventist Church accepts two ordinances: Baptism and Holy Communion.

Baptism: The Seventh-day Adventists do not baptize infants and children. They believe Baptism is only for consenting believers after the age of accountability. This ordinance is performed by full immersion in water.

Lord's Supper: The Lord's Supper or the Holy communion is the only other ordinance Seventh-day Adventists observe as a symbolic expression of faith in Jesus as Lord and Savior. Adventist Holy communion service also includes 'the service of foot washing' also known as the 'Ordinance of Humility'. The Holy communion is usually observed four times a year and usually open to all believing Christians (members and non-members). Only unfermented grape juice and unleavened bread are used for the service.

WORSHIP AND PRAYER

The seventh-day Adventist worship and prayer services are similar to those of most Protestant denominations, like Bible study, private prayer and attending church services. A key difference though is the main day for worship is a Saturday not a Sunday.

Sabbath and Saturday: Adventists are unique from the rest of the mainstream Christians in their view of observing Sabbath. The importance of observing Sabbath as in the old testament (from sundown on Friday to sundown on Saturday) was revealed to Ellen G. White in a prophetic vision. Mainstream Christians believe that they are no longer required to observe Sabbath. Also the main day of worship for the Adventist is Saturday (the day of Sabbath) unlike the rest of the Christians Sunday.

SALVATION

Like most mainstream Protestants Adventists believe salvation is through grace by faith alone. But make a important point that living a holy life (works) is a natural consequence of true faith. Adventists believe falling away (loss of salvation) is possible.

ESCHATOLOGY

The Seventh-day Adventist believe about death is unique among other Christians. They do not believe in immortality of soul (as most Christians do) rather believe in 'conditional immortality'. They believe death is an unconscious state as sleep. This state is temporary while one awaits resurrection.

They believe in a literal, personal, visible, worldwide and imminent second coming of Jesus. At his second coming only the righteous dead will be resurrected (known as first resurrection) and together with the living righteous will be transformed into glorified beings (with immortal body and soul -- conditional immortality) and together will be caught up in the clouds to meet Jesus.

They believe second coming of Jesus will mark the beginning of 'the millennium', the thousand-year reign of Jesus with his saints in heaven between the first and second resurrections. During this period the unrighteous dead will be judged while they remain sleeping. The earth in this period will be totally desolate without any human beings and will be occupied by Satan and his angels.

At the end of the millennium Jesus with His saints and the Holy City will come down from heaven to earth. Then the unrighteous dead will be resurrected . This is called second resurrection and occurs before the final judgment. After the final judgment the unrighteous will receive their punishment called the second death. Fire from God will consume the unrighteous, Satan and his angles, a total annihilation, rather than a continual and eternal conscious torment in hell (as most Christians believe).

HEALTH AND DIETARY RESTRICTIONS

Seventh-day Adventists believe that the human body is the temple of Holy Spirit and thus should be cared for properly. So, they prohibit (unlike the mainstream Christianity) the use of tobacco, alcohol recreational drugs.

They also prohibit (unlike all other Christians) pork, shellfish, and other animals proscribed as "unclean foods" as in Judaism according to the laws in Leviticus 11 (Old Testament). They also recommend vegetarian diet and abstinence from coffee, tea and caffeinated beverages.

CONTRACEPTION

Adventists allow responsible use of all forms of contraception.

ABORTION

Adventists allow abortion only for the most serious reasons. They do not allow abortions for reasons of birth control, gender selection, or convenience. Abortion is allowed in serious circumstances such as significant threats to the pregnant woman's life, serious jeopardy to her health, severe congenital defects carefully diagnosed in the fetus, and pregnancy resulting from rape or incest. They do not condone any attempts to coerce women either to remain pregnant or to terminate pregnancy.

DIVORCE AND REMARRIAGE

Marriage is divinely established lifelong union between a man and a woman who share a common faith. Seventh-day Adventist ministers do not officiate marriage between Adventist and non-Adventists.

Divorce is only allowed in the case of fornication and abandonment by a non-believing (non-SDA) spouse. Remarriage is allowed for the not guilty divorcee but the guilty divorcee may not remarry while the ex-partner lives.

FOR MORE INFORMATION (Some Sources Used For This Article)

<https://www.adventist.org/fileadmin/adventist.org/files/articles/official-statements/28Beliefs-Web.pdf>,
http://www.newworldencyclopedia.org/entry/Seventh-day_Adventist_Church,
http://www.bbc.co.uk/religion/religions/christianity/subdivisions/seventhdayadventist_1.shtml,
<http://christianity.about.com/od/seventhdayadventist/a/7thdayadventistbeliefs.htm>,
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<http://www.religioustolerance.org/sda2.htm>.